



ongoing friction between the two groups since the island became independent in 1948 has adversely affected its economy. The island is nevertheless blessed with an excellent climate for farming, seas teeming with fish,

and mineral resources such as emeralds, rubies, and graphite. The main religion of the island is Buddhism heavily infused with Hindu beliefs and practices, and the national languages are Sinhala and Tamil.

Esala Perahera

The procession, or *perahera*, that takes place in the summer month of *Esala* is an annual highlight in Kandy, a former capital of Sri Lanka nestling in the hills at the center of the country. The celebration lasts 10 days, and features nightly parades.



TOOTH TEMPLE

When King Kit Siri Mevan brought one of the Buddha's teeth to his capital city, Kandy, from India in 313 AD he paraded it through the streets in a custom that continues annually to this day. The tooth is not only an object of great devotion, but also an important symbol of Buddhist Sinhalese identity.



MALIGAWA TUSKER

Heavily ornamented and flanked by two other elephants, the Maligawa Tusker is the highlight of the procession. This elephant carries a golden casket holding the sacred relic—the Buddha's tooth.



TRADITIONAL DANCERS

Under the caste system dancers were born into their professions, which they learned from their parents. Royal patrons supplied them with land in return for dancing and performing other religious rituals. Now that dancers are hired only for special occasions, their numbers are diminishing.

A Kandyan dancer holds a spectacular mask. It may have been made in Ambalangoda in the south of the island, a town famous for its mask makers.

